a bit lonely out there, to be honest, even though the reception I got from the *madridistas* was all I could have hoped for: families everywhere, cheering and waving. I waved back. The photographers got their shots of David Beckham in a Real uniform for the very first time.

How long was I going to be out here? What else did we need to do? I kicked a ball up into the crowd behind the goal. I peered up into the stand in front of me, trying to see who'd caught it, trying to get a clue as to how these same fans would take to me when I ran out at the Bernabeu, alongside the *galacticos*, for a game. I knew I'd be back in Madrid to start work on July 24. The whirl of the last 24 hours suddenly rushed to a full stop. The significance of what had happened today and the previous day swept over me, filled my chest like a blast of pure oxygen. It felt fantastic.

Suddenly, out of the corner of my eye, while the security guards followed my line of sight up into the crowd, I saw a figure away to my left, darting out from behind the metal frame of a floodlight pylon. A lad—eleven, twelve—tanned, black hair stood on end, bare chested and wearing a pair of jean shorts and some battered trainers. And he was racing towards me. I think I saw him before anybody else did. There were shouts of surprise from the crowd. The security people swiveled and looked towards me. Too late: the boy—named Alfonso, I found out later—was standing a couple of feet away from me. It was a shock but there wasn't anything about him to make me step back. His eyes were wide open, pleading, like he wanted something from me without knowing what. My instinct was to just hold my arms out towards him. He didn't need a second invitation: he jumped at me, laughing. I caught him and held on, almost as tightly as he did. I waved away the security guys: this was just a boy who'd taken his chance. I managed to prise him off for long enough to motion over to Simon who was in front of the other stand:

'A shirt. I need another shirt.'

We walked across and met them halfway. I tried to give the shirt to him but Allows just stood in front of me, tears in his eyes now. He raised his arms at either side. I dropped the shirt over his head. This was like some weird kind of ceremony going on here. I was half-aware that people around the ground were cheering and whistling. He pushed his arms through and the shirt settled on him, almost down to his knees. He looked up at me. His eyes were like a mirror: happiness, fear, awe, the wonder of the impossible just having happened. In a couple of hours' time, I would be on a plane back to England with my family. Time to start packing our bags. Where would Allows be then? I looked down into this boy's expectant, passionate face. I could see